Scaffold

Usability Findings + Iteration Decisions

Evaluation Goal

The prototype walkthroughs explored whether Scaffold:

- reduced task-initiation friction
- clarified actionable next steps
- preserved user autonomy
- reduced overwhelm during interaction
- felt emotionally supportive rather than pressuring
- supported re-engagement during moments of cognitive overload

The walkthroughs reinforced the importance of designing support systems that reduce cognitive friction without introducing behavioral pressure or emotional escalation.

Observed Interaction Patterns

Observation 01

USERS HESITATED BEFORE COMMITTING TO TASK FLOWS

Participants appeared cautious when entering workflows that implied escalating responsibility or hidden complexity.

Interpretation

Many users associate productivity systems with pressure, failure, or obligation.

Design Response

- Increased clarity around reversibility
- Added explicit pause/exit pathways
- Reduced pressure-oriented language

Observation 02

SMALLER TASK FRAMING REDUCED ACTIVATION BARRIERS

Participants responded more positively when tasks were reframed into smaller, bounded actions.

Interpretation

Reducing ambiguity lowered emotional resistance and cognitive load.

Design Response

Expanded “make it smaller” interactions and focused on single-step progression.

Observation 03

EMOTIONAL REASSURANCE AFFECTED WILLINGNESS TO ENGAGE

Participants appeared more comfortable continuing once the system communicated safety, flexibility, and non-judgment.

Interpretation

Emotional state directly impacts task initiation capacity.

Design Response

- Softened onboarding language
- Removed punitive framing
- Increased transparency around interaction scope

Observation 04

CONCRETE NEXT STEPS REDUCED OVERWHELM

Once the system translated larger goals into actionable sequences, users appeared calmer and more able to proceed.

Interpretation

Executive friction often occurs at the translation layer between intention and executable action.

Design Response

Prioritized next-step clarity over full-task planning.

Observation 05

BOUNDED FOCUS INTERVALS SUPPORTED ENGAGEMENT

Participants responded well to structured but finite focus periods.

Interpretation

Clear time containers reduced anticipatory overwhelm.

Design Response

Refined focus-timer interactions and transition pacing.

Primary Usability Insight

Participants did not need more pressure.

They needed:

- reduced ambiguity
- emotional safety
- lower activation energy
- reversible interaction
- support that preserved agency

Iteration Decisions

Refined

- onboarding language
- task breakdown structure
- visual simplicity
- consent-based prompts
- transition pacing

Reduced

- feature density
- competing decisions
- urgency framing
- cognitive clutter

Strengthened

- transparency
- reversibility
- user control
- emotional validation